HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Not Denial, But Focus: What Perishut Really Means

Given Monday 26 October 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem 10.2

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam); Rabbeinu Avraham's commentary on the Torah for the weekly parashah

Chapter: Perek Yud (10) — **Perishut**, abstinence (Part 2: definition)

Topic: Four ideas from Rabbeinu Avraham on **Parashat Vayera** (Sarah and Yishmael's **מצחק**; Hagar's fear and **שמא יגרום החטא**; the peshat of **בעת ההיא** ;**באשר הוא שם** versus **אחרי הדברים האלה**); **why perishut matters** — the prophets' careers as shepherds and farmers, the simplicity of their lives, and the Torah's proofs from **cherem**, Yericho, Achan and Hoshea; the **roadmap** for the rest of the chapter; and the **definition**: **perishut is in the heart** — with Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov as wealthy men who were nonetheless *perushim*.

Schedule note: The clocks have changed in the UK. Throughout the winter, b'ezrat Hashem: **Monday 6:00pm — HaMaspik**; **Tuesday 8:00pm — Moreh Nebuchim**; **Thursday 6:00pm — Halacha (Hilchot Shabbat)**. *(One participant had seen 6:15 — that was last week's time, before the clocks changed. From now on it is 6:00.)*

The Weekly Feature — Rabbeinu Avraham on the Parashah

As announced last week, each week we look at something small from **Rabbeinu Avraham's commentary on the Torah**, which survives only on **Bereishit and Shemot**. Last week we saw his commentary on Bereishit; this week, **Parashat Vayera**. This week the Rabbi shared **four** ideas — "quite a lot" — before returning to the sefer.

Part One — Rabbeinu Avraham on Parashat Vayera

1. What did Sarah see? — "מצחק" (Bereishit 21:9)

ותרא שרה את בן הגר המצרית אשר ילדה לאברהם מצחק.

Sarah sees the son of Hagar — Yishmael, the older brother — **מצחק**. The Torah is deliberately playing on the word: **Yitzchak** is named for laughter, and Yishmael is **metzachek**. But there are **two kinds of שחוק**. What was the problem?

ראתה אותו מצחק ומנבל את פיו ומתנהג כדרך הנערים.

Sarah saw him **fooling around as youngsters do — and using his mouth for inappropriate speech**. *Playing around* is understandable from the word **מצחק**; where Rabbeinu Avraham gets **מנבל את פיו**, coarse language, the Rabbi doesn't know — but for some reason he adds it.

Why is that a problem? It is **מפריע מדרך השלמות** — it prevents a person from reaching perfection, as Shlomo HaMelech said in Kohelet: **לשחוק אמרתי מהולל... טוב כעס משחוק.** *When I was younger I thought it was good to laugh around; when I was older I realised that, although anger is bad, sometimes it is better than mucking around.* It shows the dangers of **שחוק used in the wrong way**.

וחששה שמא יצחק נעתק אליו ולשחוק, בהתחברו עם ישמעאל, ויבלה זמנו שעה בלא עסק בשלמות המיוחדת לו.

Sarah was afraid **Yitzchak would copy Yishmael** — remember, Yishmael is older — and, instead of using his time to work on **the perfection unique to him**, would spend it playing around.

וזה הוא הראוי שיעמוד בסגולתו... ושרה מטפלת בזה, לפי ששניהם נוכחים בבית אצלה בשעת המנוחה.

Yitzchak's task is to work on his own perfection. There was a strong relationship between Sarah and Yitzchak — understandably, he is her biological child — and they spent a great deal of time together, resting and eating together. **Very interesting:** although both are Avraham's children, Rabbeinu Avraham suggests that **Sarah took personal responsibility for Yitzchak's spiritual development**. When she saw it threatened by Yishmael's behaviour, she felt it was time to drive Yishmael out.

Two new points from Rabbeinu Avraham: (1) Yishmael was **speaking wrongly**, not just playing; (2) **Sarah saw herself as responsible** for guiding Yitzchak towards perfection.

2. Why did Hagar fear Yishmael would die? (21:16)

Yishmael and Hagar have been sent away with limited food and water, and run out. Hagar distances herself: **כי אמרה אל אראה במות הילד** — *"I don't want to see my child die."*

The question: In **last week's parashah, Lech Lecha**, the malach told Hagar that Yishmael would grow up and become a nation — **ידו בכל** — prominent and influential. So what is she worried about? How will he become a nation if he dies now? *A strong question.*

אין זה ספק מצדה בהבטחתו יתעלה שהבטיח לה, והוא יהיה פרא אדם ידו בכל ויד כל בו, אלא על דרך יראת אברהם ויעקב עליהם השלום... כשסבר שמא יגרום החטא.

The easy answer would be that Hagar doubted — she lacked proper emunah. **Rabbeinu Avraham is not comfortable with that.** He is convinced Hagar *did* trust the message. Rather — as the Rambam says (we learned it together in **Shemonah Perakim**, and it appears in many other sefarim) — **שמא יגרום החטא**: even when one has been promised something, **such promises are often conditional**. If a person misbehaves, he can lose them.

So she had **full faith** in the promise — and at the same time feared that **sin** (Yishmael's, her own, or both) could stop it.

A question from Mark: *The obvious parallel is the Akedah. Avraham was promised Yitzchak would become a great nation — and then told to slaughter him.*

The Rabbi: Someone (he couldn't recall who) says that this was **part of the test** itself: *you've been told clearly that you and your son will become a great nation — will you now doubt that prophecy?* Avraham didn't doubt, and went ahead. Whatever one answers for Avraham and Yitzchak, answer the same for Hagar and Yishmael. *Fair point.*

3. "באשר הוא שם" — the simple meaning (21:17)

וישמע אלהים את קול הנער, ויקרא מלאך אלהים אל הגר מן השמים... אל תיראי כי שמע אלהים אל קול הנער באשר הוא שם.

The well-known interpretation (Chazal — the one we discuss on Rosh Hashanah): *where he is now* — although Yishmael will later do bad things, **at this moment** his identity is good, and he is judged as he is now.

But, says Rabbeinu Avraham, that is not the simple reading:

פשטי דקרא, שהביט הקדוש ברוך הוא יתעלה במצבו וצערו שהוא בו, במקום שבו עזבתו אמו — תחת אחד השיחים.

Geographically, not spiritually: Hashem heard the child crying **where he physically was** — abandoned, alone, under one of the bushes. *"I always read the verse as 'where he is now'. That's why I wanted to share it with you."*

4. "ויהי בעת ההיא" vs "אחרי הדברים האלה" — a principle for the whole Torah

After Yishmael grows up in the wilderness, the Torah says **ויהי בעת ההיא** — *and it was at that time* — and moves to the covenant between Avraham and Avimelech. What does *at that time* mean?

ויהי בעת ההיא — מורה על הזמן שלא הוגדר במקרא, שהוא כינוי החוזר על העת, ואותה העת לא הוגדרה; ואפשר שתהיה העת מורה על הזמן של הסיפור שקדם זכרונו, או... על הזמן של הסיפור שיבוא אחר כך.

Phrase	Meaning
ויהי בעת ההיא — "at that time"	**Vague.** It may refer to the story **before** it, or to the story **after** it. We simply don't know.
אחרי הדברים האלה — "after these things"	**Defined.** It always refers to the time of the story itself.

וזה פירוש שאני מעתיק מן אבא מרי — *this I have from my father* (the Rambam). The Rabbi has not seen this anywhere in the Rambam's own writings; this may be its only source.

The proof — Devarim, Parashat Eikev:

ובני ישראל נסעו מבארות בני יעקן מוסרה, שם מת אהרן ויקבר שם, ויכהן אלעזר בנו תחתיו... בעת ההיא הבדיל ה' את שבט הלוי.

- Aharon's death is in **the 40th year** after leaving Egypt.
- Straight afterwards: **בעת ההיא** Hashem separated the tribe of Levi — which happened in **the 2nd year** (Korach / the inauguration of the Leviim).

So **בעת ההיא** is open-ended. In Vayera, **ויהי בעת ההיא** could refer back to the whole narrative of Yishmael in the desert, or forward to the covenant with Avimelech — but **not** necessarily to either.

Part Two — Recap of Chapter 10 So Far

- **Last week:** a **review of the entire book** so far — *"if you haven't listened to it, I'd advise listening to get an overview of what we've learned"* — and the start of Chapter 10.
- We didn't yet go into abstinence properly; we began with the idea of **not being too attached to this world**.
- **A human being is חומר (matter) and צורה (form / consciousness).** Neither is non-functional, but someone who pursues his material identity **weakens his tzurah** and will not be able to enjoy **Olam HaBa** properly. We discussed Rabbeinu Avraham's view of Olam HaBa — *"a very interesting discussion."*
- **Before defining perishut, Rabbeinu Avraham first explains how important it is.**

Part Three — Why Perishut Matters

הפרישות אפוא מן המידות התרומיות המוליכות לאהבת ה'.

Perishut is one of the lofty character traits that lead to the love of Hashem.

כי חסיד הפרוש — אין לבו טרוד בדאגות עולמיות, ויש לו פנאי להגות במה שיכונן כוונתו, ועיתותיו חופשיות מן העייפות והיגע.

The *parush* is **not preoccupied with worldly worries**, has **time to contemplate** what matters, and is not constantly worn out trying to make money —

מפני שהוא משתמש בהשגת מה שמספיק, מה שדרוש בהכרח בעולם הזה — כגון לחם לאכול ובגד ללבוש.

— because he seeks only **what is necessary**, and uses the rest of his time in the search for meaning, spirituality and personal development.

ואם יסתפק אדם בדרוש ובהכרחי — לא תקשה עליו השגתם. ולכן ראינו את בקשת יעקב אבינו: לחם לאכול ובגד ללבוש.

Most people don't struggle to obtain the basics. This is why **Yaakov**, asking Hashem for help, asked only for **bread to eat and clothes to wear** — a point Rabbeinu Avraham made in **Chapter 8 (Bitachon)**: it is right to have bitachon for the basics, **but not for extravagance**. Focus on the basics and you will have time for what is more important than your *chomer*.

The careers of the prophets and the righteous

והנביאים והחסידים נטו לבחור במחייתם במרעית הצאן ועבודת האדמה.

The prophets and the righteous chose work that took **little time**, leaving the rest for meditation, concentration and growth — **shepherds and farmers**.

כי הרועה ינהג צאנו שעה אחת ביום לרעות הדשא, וישב יפקח עליהם עין, ובשאר שעה יפקח בלבו לשלמות — בפרט אם מקום המרעה במדבר ובערבה ובמקומות הרחוקים מן הישוב, כמו שנוסיף לגלות אזניך בפרק הבדידות.

- **A shepherd** leads the flock for an hour, then simply watches over it — and while watching, is free to think. And the pastures are usually in **solitude**, far from settlement. (More on this in the coming **chapter on hitbodedut**.)

ועובד אדמה מתייגע רק בעת הזרע והקציר, ואילו בשאר עונות השנה ישבות בלבדו.

- **A farmer** works hard only at **sowing and harvest** — the start of winter, the start of summer. The rest of the year he is free.

ולכן היה אלישע איכר, וכן אבא חלקיה ועוד כיוצא בהם. Elisha was a **ploughman**; Abba Chilkiya likewise. He doesn't bother listing the shepherds — we know **Moshe Rabbeinu and David HaMelech** were shepherds.

Two reasons: such work (1) gives you **free time**, and (2) keeps you **away from crowds**. So Rabbeinu Avraham's advice when choosing a career: **choose work that leaves you time to develop, and in which you deal with as few people as possible.** *(A rabbi certainly satisfies the first — "well, okay, I shouldn't say that; it depends on your community" — but certainly not the second!)*

Class discussion: what is the modern equivalent?

Suggestion	Discussion
Trading stocks — alone, potentially	The Rabbi knows many traders: in the office at six, not a second free all day. That is **the pursuit of more mammon** — money makes more money, and more desire. *(A participant: "My son trades bonds and futures — he said 'Mum, I'll be burnt out by 26', and he's still at it.")*
A teacher of Torah	You learn while you work — but teachers today work extremely hard, with all the extra work after hours.
A shopkeeper	Employ someone for some days and work three hours a day yourself — as we know of the **Chafetz Chaim** (whose shop famously supported him).
A chazan	*"That's true, actually"* — sing here and there, and if it's a full salary you don't have to deal with people much.

It is very hard today, unless you are self-employed.

The simple lives of the prophets

ושמואל הרמתי הייתה מתנתו רבע שקל כסף; ואחיה השילוני — בקבוק דבש ועשרה לחם ונקודים; אליהו — כסותו אזור עור ואדרת שער; אלישע — סעודתו למאה איש בני נביאים עשרים לחם שעורים וכרמל בצקלונו.

- **Shmuel** accepted a **quarter of a shekel** from those who visited him.
- **Achiya HaShiloni** — a flask of honey and some bread.
- **Eliyahu** — a leather belt and a hairy cloak.
- **Elisha** — for himself and **a hundred students**, twenty barley loaves.

ודירתם — בית מגורם בנוי מחומר פשוט, כמו שנאמר: נלכה נא עד הירדן ונקחה משם איש קורה אחת ונעשה לנו שם מקום לשבת שם. The *bnei nevi'im* would go to the Jordan, each take a single beam, and build a little place to live — **happy with a little roof over their heads**.

ואולם היה מקרה רע, שהאחד מהם דאג על אבדת גרזנו, שלא היה לו כסף לרוכשו, ולכן שאלו. One of them lost an axe — and couldn't afford another; he had **borrowed** it.

ואבא חלקיה היה חורש שכיר יום, גלימתו שאולה. Abba Chilkiya was a **hired day-labourer**, in a borrowed cloak.

הנה כי כן יתחבר לך כי הפרישות היא מהמידות... כמחייב השכל הישר. From all this you see that perishut is an important trait, as straightforward reason requires.

Proofs from the Torah

(1) Mitzvot that train us not to over-indulge

ולכן ציוותה התורה... — the Torah gave **many mitzvot** for this purpose, as the **Rambam explains in the Moreh**: mitzvot given so that we don't become too focused on things.

The Rabbi adds: Rabbeinu Avraham doesn't say this about **kashrut**, but Rabbi Shimshon Raphael Hirsch (or a contemporary) does — the general idea of kashrut is **to restrain**: removing the blood, shechitah, permitted and forbidden animals — mitzvot that train us not to fall into indulgence.

(2) Cherem after the war with the Canaanite (Parashat Chukat)

אם נתן תתן את העם הזה בידי, והחרמתי את עריהם... וישמע ה' בקול ישראל ויתן את הכנעני, ויחרם אתהם ואת עריהם.

Bnei Yisrael vowed: *if You give us victory, we will **consecrate** their cities* — and not take the spoils. Hashem listened; they won, and consecrated it.

This is a machloket rishonim:

Reading of חרם	Who
To consecrate — as in the *charamim* of Parashat Bechukotai	**Rabbeinu Avraham** and **Rashi**
To destroy — **ענינו לכלות ולהחרים הערים מהם**, as in **החרם תחרים אותם** (the seven nations) and the *cherem* of Achan	**Ralbag**

Why one word for both? *The Rabbi:* when you consecrate something, **you destroy your personal connection to it**. *"I think that's pashut — that's the connection between the words."* So the proof is good, **but not 100%** — one could read it like the Ralbag.

An objection Rabbeinu Avraham raises himself: ואם יאמר, כי דבר זה אירע מפני שהיו אסורים אז ליכנס לארץ, כפי תום ארבעים שנה. Perhaps they consecrated it only because this was the 40th year: the Canaanites came from the Land, Bnei Yisrael were not yet allowed to enter it — and perhaps not to benefit from it either.

His answer — Yericho and Achan: נזכיר עוד ציווי... בענין יריחו ששם הושם חרם, ואת העונש הנורא שנענש עכן... מפני שמעל בחרם.

- **Yericho** too was made *cherem*. *(The commentators cite the **Radak**: we never actually find that Hashem commanded it — either Hashem told Yehoshua and it isn't written, or it was Yehoshua's own decision. Either way, it is a proof that consecration and perishut are good.)*
- **Achan** — his clan was caught, then he himself, and he was put to death for taking from the spoils.

וזה ראיה נצחת ומוראת למי שניתן לו רוח בבטנו... — this should suffice for any thinking person to recognise that **the Torah recognises, and demands, perishut**.

(3) Hoshea — indulgence alongside idolatry

כאהבת ה' את בני ישראל, והם פנים אל אלהים אחרים ואהבי אשישי ענבים. (Hoshea 3:1)

Hashem loves Bnei Yisrael — but instead of reciprocating, they turn **to other gods** — and **to fine wine**.

דימה הכתוב את אהבת תענוגות העולם הזה למראה כפני עבודה זרה... וזו ראיה חותכת, כי הפרישות מענייני העולם הזה — התקרבות אל אהבת האל, והתעמקות בהתחברות אליו.

The verse compares the love of worldly pleasure to idolatry. A **decisive proof**: the more you love this world, the further you are from Hashem — and perishut brings you close.

So far: last week, the importance of not focusing too much on materialism; this week, that **perishut is an important trait**, with proofs from consecration and elsewhere in the Torah. *Lovely. But what **is** it?*

Part Four — The Roadmap for the Rest of Chapter 10

וכיון שבארנו נחיצות הפרישות — הבה נבאר לך את מהותה, ודרכי הכושר להשגתה, והחזקה בהגתה, ואחר כך את פרותיה ותוצאותיה, ואחר כך ניישב קושיות הבאות בסדר השגתה.

#	Stage	When
1	**Its definition** (*מהותה*)	**This week**
2	**How to train towards it** (*דרכי הכושר להשגתה*)	**Next week**
3	**How to know you've achieved it** (*החזקה בהגתה*)	Coming weeks
4	**Its fruits and consequences** (*פרותיה ותוצאותיה*)	Coming weeks
5	**Resolving stories in Tanach that seem to contradict it**	Around **Parashat Toldot** — a lengthy discussion of **Yitzchak's blessings**, which will fall perfectly in two or three weeks, at the end of the chapter

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Part Five — The Definition: Perishut Is in the Heart

ונאמר כי עיקר הפרישות הוא שתהא יוצאת מן הלב — שהלב פרוש מאהבת העולם הזה, ותהיינה עיניו שקועות בתורה ובעבודת השם, אחד עמו, מאס בכל שאר הדברים מלבדו.

"This is the most important line" — of the shiur, and of the whole chapter.

A person is where his mind is (perhaps the Baal Shem Tov). Rabbeinu Avraham is **not** asking you to fast, abstain from wine, abstain from this and that — **while thinking about it all the time**. That is not perishut. *"You've missed the boat."* **Perishut is in the heart.** How to get there is very hard — that's next week — but first, understand the definition.

Like humility

We've discussed this before — even in HaMaspik itself. **Humility doesn't mean thinking low of yourself.** *"I've got talent, I'm good at this — Hashem bless you then."* There's an English saying along the

lines of: ***humility is not thinking less of yourself, it's thinking of yourself less.*** Anavah is not walking around all day thinking *"I'm so low, I'm trying to be humble"* — that defeats the point. **Stop focusing on yourself.**

So too perishut isn't spending the whole day thinking, *"I didn't eat today, I'm so holy, I wish I could have that chocolate but I'm abstaining for Hashem"* — while sitting in the shiur thinking about the chocolate. **That doesn't help.** Perishut means: **"I have no interest in these things — because my focus is on something else."**

Two ways to lose interest — the diet analogy

Level	What it looks like
1 — Trained restraint	You've dieted long enough that when you see unhealthy food you have no desire for it. But it comes from *"theoretically, if it had no calories, I'd love it."*
2 — Absorbed elsewhere (true perishut)	You lost weight **not** by dieting, but because you're **so busy with another project** — work, family, whatever — that you **don't have time to think** about those foods.

Perishut means a person is so focused on the pursuit of his relationship with Hakadosh Baruch Hu, and the development of his spiritual identity and intellect, that he has no time to think about these things.

> **כי עיקר הפרישות הוא שתהיה יוצאת מן הלב — רוצה לומר, שהלב פרוש מן העולם הזה, ושקוע באהבתו יתעלה ובעבודתו ושמחתו... שאינו מתאוה.**

Wealth is no contradiction

> **וככה נראה שפרוש זה — ילבש בגדי משי, ויאכל מעדנים, ויתענג בתענוגים... אלא אם באו לו נכסים אלו בלא כוונה מצדו, מירושה וכדומה, או בתמצות מועטת להשגת דמי החיים.**

A *parush* may wear silk, eat delicacies and live in a beautiful home — **if these came to him without his pursuing them**: an inheritance, a gift, or ordinary modest effort. *"I have it now, I enjoy it — but it's not on my mind."* **It is not about what I have; it is about what is on my mind.** You can live well, dress well, eat well and sleep well and still be a *parush*.

- **Yitzchak: ויזרע יצחק בארץ ההיא, וימצא בשנה ההיא מאה שערים, ויברכהו ה'.** He did ordinary farming and received **a hundredfold** — without chasing extra money.
- **Yaakov:** despite Lavan, **ויפרץ האיש מאד מאד, ויהי לו צאן רבות ושפחות ועבדים וגמלים וחמרים.** He became extremely wealthy.
- **Avraham: ואברם כבד מאד במקנה בכסף ובזהב** (read last Shabbat) — extremely wealthy, **and still a parush**.

How do we know Avraham was a *parush*?

(1) One wife

The strongest drive in men, Rabbeinu Avraham says, is **women** — and a wealthy man could have married many.

והתרחק מן הדבר הזה — לא לקח אשה אחרת על אשתו, בלעדי הגר, וגם זאת ברשות שרה, ורק כדי להביא זרע.

Rabbeinu Avraham insists in several places in his Torah commentary that **the ideal is one wife**. The Torah permits more; the **Chachamim** advised **not more than four**, for the women's emotional sake. But the ideal:

- **Adam and Chava** — one and one.
- **Yitzchak and Rivka** — one and one.
- **Yaakov** wanted only **Rachel**. Lavan tricked him into Leah; he then married Rachel, whom he really wanted; when Rachel couldn't have children he took another — and ended with four. **That wasn't his plan.**
- **Avraham** — only Sarah; Hagar only at Sarah's request, for children.

(2) Sarah's beauty was never the focal point

Avimelech took her to his palace — **התבונן ביופיה של שרה... עד שאפילו בימי זקנתה חשקוה אנשי הארץ at ninety**. *(Why he cites Avimelech rather than Pharaoh the Rabbi wasn't sure — perhaps because there her age is explicit.)*

וחז"ל אמרו כי לא התבונן אברהם אבינו ביפיה והדרה עד שבא למצרים, וזה סיבת מאמרו: הנה נא ידעתי כי אשה יפת מראה את.

The famous midrash — *"now I know"* — doesn't mean Avraham had never looked at his wife. *Of course* he saw her and appreciated her beauty. **It simply was never the focal point of their relationship.** Now they were going to **Mitzrayim** — *עגלה יפהפיה מצרים* — a society where **beauty is the focus** (it ties into Chanukah, as discussed in the past). So now they had to be careful. Being a *parush* doesn't mean marrying someone unattractive or living in poverty — **it means it isn't your focus.**

(3) Keturah — not Hagar

ומה שלקח אברהם אבינו את קטורה אחר מות שרה... ויסף אברהם ויקח אשה ושמה קטורה (next week's parashah, Chayei Sarah).

The Midrash (cited by **Rashi**) says Keturah **was Hagar** — then there's no question; he had no wife and took her back. But **Rabbeinu Avraham holds she was a third woman.** So why would a *parush* marry again?

לא היה זה אלא על פי רוח הקודש, או ציווי שאינו כתוב בתורה, ותכליתו לפרסם המשך הנס שנולד יצחק באחרית הימים...

By Divine instruction — to publicise the miracle that **even beyond 140** he could still father children.

How does he know Avraham was over 140? The Rabbi could see 137 (Sarah died at 127; Avraham was ten years older) but not 140 — until **Donna** pointed out: **Avraham was 100 when Yitzchak was born, and Yitzchak was 40 when he married Rivka** (start of Toldot). So Avraham was **140 at Yitzchak's wedding**, and Keturah came after. *"Excellent — clearly. Pashut."*

(4) Refusing the spoils of Sedom

אם מחוט ועד שרוך נעל, ואם אקח מכל אשר לך, ולא תאמר אני העשרתי את אברם. (Lech Lecha)

After defeating the four kings, Avraham refused even **a shoelace** from the king of Sedom. **He didn't care.**

Who is *not* a *parush*

ולכן אין לומר על כל עני שרואים אותו לבוש קרעים ואוכל חתיכות פת חרבה שהוא פרוש...

- **Not every poor person** living simply is a *parush* — he has no choice.

אפילו מי שסיגל עצמו בדרכי פשיטות — לבישת בגדים גסים ואכילת מאכלים תפלים כגון פת יבשה, ויתבודד במדברות ובחדרים וכיוצא בהם — אלא על תנאי שלבו מרוחק מן העולם הזה, ולא ירצה בהם ולא ישתוקק לשום אחד אשר בעולם...

- **Even someone who has trained himself** in coarse clothes, plain food and solitude **is not a parush — unless his heart is detached** from this world.

אמור מעתה: מי שמרוחק בלבו מאהבת העולם הזה — הוא הפרוש האמתי. ומי שמשתוקק אליהם, ולבו בוער באהבתם, ומצטער על חסרונם — איננו שום פרוש. וזה דבר שראוי לך לתת דעתך עליו.

In conclusion: if in your heart you don't care about these things — **you are the true parush**. If you long for them, even while not living with them — **you are not a parush at all**.

Something we can all work on

The most important thing to take from this shiur — and from the whole chapter — is that **perishut is in the heart**. How a person lives is not the main point; **it is about the attention we give these things.** Fasting and wearing simple clothes may be hard to relate to in our generation — *"at least for me myself"* — but **developing the heart is something every one of us can work on**.

The honest test: if our desire for material things is stronger than our desire for spiritual growth, that's a problem.

Do I get more excited when I've understood something new in the Rambam, in the Torah — or when I've been given a new cheque?

Summary

Rabbeinu Avraham on Vayera: Sarah saw Yishmael fooling around **and speaking coarsely**, and, feeling personally responsible for **Yitzchak's perfection**, sent him away. Hagar didn't doubt the promise — she feared **שמא יגרום החטא**, since promises can be conditional (and the Akedah, as part of Avraham's test, raises the same question). **באשר הוא שם** in its simple meaning is *where he physically lay*, under the bush. And **בעת ההיא** is vague (before or after), whereas **אחרי הדברים האלה** is definite — proven from Devarim, where *at that time* follows the 40th year but refers to the 2nd.

The importance of perishut: it frees the heart from worry and the time from toil; the prophets chose to be **shepherds and farmers** for free time and solitude, and lived extremely simply. The Torah's mitzvot train restraint; **cherem** (consecration, per Rabbeinu Avraham and Rashi; destruction, per Ralbag), **Yericho** and **Achan** show the Torah values it; and **Hoshea** compares love of pleasure to idolatry.

The definition: perishut is in the heart — not in fasting while longing, but in being **so absorbed in serving Hashem that one has no interest** in the rest. Like humility — thinking of yourself less, not less of yourself. Wealth that comes unsought is no contradiction: **Yitzchak, Yaakov and Avraham** were wealthy *perushim*. Avraham's single marriage, Sarah's beauty never being his focus, Keturah by Divine instruction after 140, and his refusal of Sedom's spoils all show it. **A poor man, or even a trained ascetic whose heart still longs, is not a parush.**

Coming Up

- **Next week, Monday 6:00pm: how to attain perishut** — two levels, and the means of training towards it. *"That'll be the whole shiur next week."*
- Then: how to know you've achieved it; its fruits; and the contradictions in Tanach — with **Yitzchak's blessings** around **Parashat Toldot**.
- A short idea from **Rabbeinu Avraham on the parashah** each week through Bereishit and Shemot.
- **Tuesday 8:00pm — Moreh Nebuchim** ("a fascinating shiur" — listen to last week's first if you're following). **Thursday 6:00pm — Halacha.**

B'Ezrat Hashem

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/mNPbdKlac50 · More shiurim: rabbikada.com